INTERNATIONAL TERRORISM: AN OVERVIEW

The history of terrorism, however, can be traced to the 1st century C.E. when two Jewish groups, the Zealots and the Sicarii were formed to launch terrorist campaigns against the Roman occupation of Judea. In 666 C.E., a radical Muslim group, the Kharjites carried out routined assassinations of Muslim leaders who were found to be at fault by them. The 'Assassins' were another Muslim terrorist group, which was active during the twelfth and thirteenth centuries. The 'Hashashin' was another such group of medieval Islam.[3]

The Nardonaya Volya (the Peoples Will) of the nineteenth century was one of the first modern kind of terrorist groups and it targeted the Czarist officials for assassinations to arouse social revolt. The assassinations of Czar Alexander II in 1881 and that of Archduke Franz Ferdinand in 1914 are some of the noteworthy events of the nineteenth century where violence was used by some political groups especially by the anarchists and the nationalists to achieve their goals.[4] The 1920s witnessed an active right-wing terrorism among the German Nazis and the Italian Fascists to intimidate political enemies and attract public attention. However, the functioning of some groups in Eastern Europe, unlike the present terrorists, were almost like that of criminal gangs. Similarly, the contras of Nicaragua associated with the anti-communist dictatorship in Haiti, Argentina and Mozambique relied heavily on the right-wing 'death-squads'. They were active throughout the 1980s but their functioning was more or less like the criminal gangs. But the irony is that the West working with their Cold War calculations seemed to tolerate terrorism by such gangs regarding it as a lesser menace than the threat of communism. Therefore, President Ronald Reagan and George W. Bush (Sr.) regarded the contras and the Mujahideen guerillas of Afghanistan as 'freedom fighters' and at present the paradox is that against the backdrop of 9/11, the USA is fighting the War on Terror in Afghanistan and Iraq. Personal interpretation plays a critical role in assessing modern terrorism. Terrorist to one is often a 'freedom fighter' to another. Sometimes, other terms are also euphemistically used such as separatists, liberator, revolutionary,